‘Rohingya’ as their ethnic identity.[32] In addition, the NLD has accepted the banning of individual candidates from the wider Muslim community.

So far the NLD has found it convenient to remain silent on the question of the Rohingyas and anti-Muslim violence. Even when it has met with civil society groups to oppose the recent ban on marriages between Burmese women and Muslim men,[33] this has been presented as an issue around women’s rights rather than religious discrimination—an accurate and valid response but one that deliberately misses the reason why the laws were introduced. Other than this, the NLD seems unprepared to do much beyond vaguely condemning inter-communal violence and discrimination.

Despite this, many Rohingyas still hope that the NLD’s electoral success in 2015 might change their situation for the better.[34] There is some evidence that many plan to flee if the situation in the camps does not improve (as is discussed further below). But the NLD’s victory provides some hope, with some Rohingyas believing that the party might try to reduce current levels of persecution. This attitude of limited hope has been summed up by Kyaw Min (who was the leader of the mainly Rohingya Democracy and Human Rights Party before being banned from standing): ‘I would not say that I am disappointed with her because she has to operate in this country with the mood here now. I am sure that things will be better for us if the NLD wins the elections’.[35] Whether or not, without external pressure, the NLD either can or wants to make changes is an issue discussed in the next chapter.

It is not just the Muslim community that the NLD abandoned in the 2015 electoral cycle. Their list of candidates included only one prominent representative of the generation who took part in the 1988 uprising.[36] In addition to the low number of female candidates, this supports a fear that the NLD is seeking to ensure its parliamentary ranks include very few who would oppose a post-election deal with the USDP.[37] This may be pragmatic: Aung San Suu Kyi is desperate to have the bar on her being president lifted, and the NLD’s policies may be designed to lessen the risk of a post-election coup. However, they increase the chances that the post-election government in Myanmar will be unable to deepen the democratic process and amend those parts of the 2008 Constitution that embeds the power of the military, as they have lost some key voices who would have pressed for more radical change.